

Session 1: How We Read the Flood Story

Key Takeaways

- In order to understand what the biblical authors intend to communicate, the literary, cultural, and historic context of Genesis must take precedence over modern questions and concerns.
- Genesis 1-11 is intricately designed to introduce the themes, vocabulary, and ideas needed to understand the rest of the Hebrew Bible.
- Jesus and his contemporaries assume the three-part organization of the Hebrew Scriptures called the TaNaK.

Reading Ancient Jewish Meditation Literature

The TaNaK as a Composite Unity

Sections	Scrolls
Torah (The Law)	Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy
Nevi'im (The Prophets)	Former Prophets: Joshua, Judges, Samuel, Kings
	Latter Prophets: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadaiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zaphaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi
Ketuvim (The Writings)	Psalms, Job, Proverbs, Ruth, Song of Songs, Ecclesiastes, Lementations, Esther [The Megillot], Daniel, Ezra, Nehemiah, Chronicles
Three-Part Collection of the Hebrew Bible. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).	

The Hebrew Bible is a set of ancient Israelite scrolls that were formed into an editorial unity over the course of their composition and collection. Their final shape dates to sometime in the 3rd-2nd century B.C.E.

They were given a three-part macro design, and this order is preserved in modern Jewish tradition and is well attested in Second Temple Jewish texts and in the New Testament.

When Jesus alludes to the order of the Hebrew Bible, he assumes a three-part design, which agrees with other contemporary Jewish authors who also allude to the ordered sections.

Luke 24:44 NIV

... "This is what I told you while I was still with you: Everything must be fulfilled that is written about me in the Torah of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms."

Luke 11:50-51a NIV

⁵⁰ Therefore this generation will be held responsible for the blood of all the prophets that has been shed since the beginning of the world, ⁵¹ from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah, who was killed between the altar and the sanctuary.

Abel was murdered by Cain in [Genesis 4](#), and Zechariah son of Jehoiada was murdered by Joash in [2 Chronicles 24](#), which corresponds to the TaNaK order.

"Many great teachings have been given to us through the Law [= Torah], and the Prophets [= Nevi'im], and the others that follow them [= Ketuvim] ... So my grandfather Yeshua devoted himself especially to the reading of the Law and the Prophets and the other scrolls of our Ancestors."

Prologue to *The Wisdom of Ben Sirach*.

"The scrolls of Moses, the words of the prophets, and of David."

Dead Sea Scrolls (4QMMT).

"The laws and the oracles given by inspiration through the prophets and the Psalms, and the other scrolls whereby knowledge and piety are increased and completed."

Philo of Alexandria, *De Vita Contemplativa*, 25.

Reflection Question

In your experience of reading the flood story, what elements of the story make the least sense to you? What about the narrative challenges you the most?

The Many Potential Contexts of the Story of Noah and the Flood

In our modern cultural setting, the Noah story has been made to speak to many topics that the biblical authors did not mean to address. We must be vigilant to distinguish between asking what Genesis 6-11 means within the context of the TaNaK versus what it means for other areas of interest. The difference is one of intention. The biblical authors actually intended the stories to address the main issues of concern at work in the TaNaK, not our modern concerns. Genesis 6-11 may have significance for how we think about other topics in light of the biblical perspective, but we should not mistake this for the meaning of Genesis 6-11 in its native context.

Meaning		Significance		
Genesis 6-11	TaNaK	Introduction to Geology	A Primer on Animal Biology	Ancient Shipbuilding
				
<i>The Meaning Versus Significance of Genesis 6-11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>				

Reflection Question

According to Jesus, what is the Hebrew Bible (the Torah, the Prophets, and the Psalms) all about?